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Radical change? Ideological and affective territorial polarisation after radical parties' breakthrough in Spain

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Radical parties are on the rise in Europe. However, there is scant evidence on whether their breakthroughs affect voters' political attitudes, particularly with regard to non-economic dimensions of electoral competition. We address these gaps using a combination of panel surveys developed during recent general election cycles (2011, 2015 and 2019) in Spain. We show that the breakthrough of Podemos and Vox in 2015 and 2019 respectively contributed to the ideological polarisation of voters' positions on the highly salient territorial dimension in this country, a phenomenon that we do not observe in 2011. However, affective territorial polarisation was not achieved.

Keywords: radical right; radical left; parliamentary representation; general elections; centre-periphery; panel studies; Vox; Podemos.

The 2019 electoral cycle in Spain saw the end of what until then had been dubbed 'Iberian exceptionalism' (Turnbull-Dugarte 2019; Mendes & Dennison 2020). To mark one of the last episodes of the political turmoil that followed the economic backlash of the Great Recession (Vidal 2018), Spain joined the majority group of European countries which in recent years have introduced a radical right party in parliament. It also became a member of an alternative minority group, which comprises countries with sizeable support for both left- and right-wing radical representation in their national legislatures.

Following this, Spanish politics has experienced a process of party system fragmentation (Orriols & Cordero 2016) that has put ideological (Simón 2020) and affective polarisation (Gidron, Adams & Horne 2020; Martini & Torcal 2019) under the spotlight. The representation of radical parties – those that take more extreme positions than the rest of their competitors (Bischof & Wagner 2019) – is thought to bring about polarisation among citizens (Mudde 2013).¹ Yet understanding the direction of the causality behind these transformative events represents a research effort that has only

lately received some attention (Riera & Pastor 2021). One may look at whether voters become polarised when radical parties gain political representation or, conversely, whether radical parties only reflect pre-existing societal conflict. In a recent piece, Bischof and Wagner (2019) demonstrate that radical parties' first entrance into parliament has both short-term and long-term effects on ideological polarisation in the classical left–right dimension.

Applying this logic to the intricacies of the Spanish case seems particularly necessary to elucidate all sources of political disagreement. This is especially true when it comes to salient non-economic dimensions of political competition, such as the territorial one in Spain. In fact, focusing on the impact of the presence of radical parties on these dimensions of competition might be essential if, as recent literature suggests, they choose to compete predominantly on the basis of non-economic issues while blurring their positions on more traditional economic issues (Rovny 2013) to maximise their electoral support.

Territorial conflict is crucial to understand the configuration of Spanish politics (Gunther & Montero 1994). Such conflict has traditionally revolved around tensions on varying preferences toward the territorial organisation of the State, ranging from the recognition of secession as a viable choice for *autonomous communities*² to the absolute centralisation of power under a unitary state (Torcal & Mota 2014). Thus, it has been significantly shaped by both the institutional framework and the historical presence of non-state-wide parties' (i.e., *Partidos de Ámbito No Estatal* [PANEs]) in certain autonomous communities. PANEs are those parties with relatively small but concentrated constituencies that have managed to consolidate their presence in these arenas. They have pushed their pro-decentralisation agendas further by becoming essential to the formation

of many national governments. The centrifugal dynamics that derive from existing incentives for ethnic outbidding have been extensively documented in the comparative literature (Heller 2002; Alonso 2012; Amat & Falcó 2014; Elias, Szöcik & Zuber 2015; Massetti & Schakel 2015). However, much less is known about the effect of the electoral emergence and success of radical parties on territorial polarisation.³

In this article, we argue and empirically demonstrate that the parliamentary successes of Podemos (We Can) and Vox (Voice) have significantly contributed to the ‘reinvigoration’ of the territorial dimension of the conflict in Spain after the 2015 general elections (Vidal & Sánchez-Vítores 2019). As we assume that elections represent moments of high political conflict, spread of information, mobilisation and activation of political identities (Hernández, Anduiza & Rico 2021), our identification strategy exploits variation in the pre- and post-electoral waves of panel studies that were developed in three recent general election cycles in Spain (2011, 2015 and 2019). In 2011 and 2015 the panel survey data come from the Spanish CIS (Centro de Investigaciones Sociológicas - Center for Sociological Research) and in 2019 from the E-Dem project (Torcal et al. 2020). Hence, we compare elections when radical parties entered the parliament (December 2015 and April 2019) with those when these parties were absent (October 2011), establishing the baseline for the comparison of the effects produced by the emergence of the two aforementioned parties. Our study covers a 10-year span. Thus, our research design enables us to capture the magnitude and direction of short-term increases in polarisation as immediate reactions to these disruptive events, without neglecting the possibility of observing an accumulated increase in ideological territorial polarisation throughout the period under scrutiny.

The present article is laid out as follows. First, we theorise about how radical parties' entry to parliament affects non-economic issue polarisation and we elaborate on the extraordinary salience of the territorial dimension of conflict in Spanish politics. Next, we explain our criteria for selecting the cases, our research design and our different measures of polarisation on the mentioned dimension. We then present our results, which indicate that the parliamentary breakthrough of Podemos in 2015 and Vox in 2019 immediately increased voters' territorial polarisation – a result we do not observe in 2011. As we explain and demonstrate, this polarisation does not have an affective component. Moreover, we further examine the short-term fluctuations related to the directionality of the effect depending on party identification. Finally, we discuss the implications of our findings.

The consequences of radical parties' breakthrough

The electoral success of a radical party can significantly alter a country's political system by attracting the attention of media and triggering reactions from established political parties (Abou-Chadi 2016; Abou-Chadi & Krause 2020). Radical parties, however, do not only affect traditional issues which other parties choose to politicise, or their positions on those dimensions. Radical parties engage with and enhance other social and cultural conflicts (e.g., supranational integration, migration, etc.) (Rovny 2013), and thus non-economic issues have increasingly been gaining attention between elections (Kriesi et al. 2008).

Apart from bringing about changes at the party level, radical parties also trigger voters' reactions (Castanho Silva 2018) by informing them about the distribution of political preferences among the whole electorate. Consequently, evidence shows that, overall, voters are increasingly polarised on non-economic issue dimensions (Green-

Pedersen & Otjes 2019; Hutter, Grande & Kriesi 2016; Krause 2020). Nevertheless, the specific way in which each voter interprets party signals and changes her attitudinal profile depends on her prior political beliefs. Following Bischof and Wagner (2019), the present article distinguishes between legitimisation and backlash effects after the parliamentary breakthrough of radical parties. Because of these two effects, we expect to observe a polarisation effect taking place in non-economic dimensions of competition too. In particular, we will focus here on the centre-periphery (or *territorial*) dimension in Spain, which, as we develop in the next section, has an exceptional salience in this country.

First, the new entry of a radical party to parliament might have a legitimisation effect. People identifying with the views of this party will express more extreme views due to a combination of the following two facts. On the one hand, voters will feel freer to declare their pre-existing opinions, which may be radical, in a context where they consider that many people support these views. Like other realms of social life, political behaviour is regulated by norms that dictate which sets of opinions are deemed appropriate. The entrance of a radical party into parliament breaches several of these established norms (Mudde 2004). Moreover, the success of these parties normalises previously stigmatised behaviours (Bursztyn, Egorov & Fiorin 2017). Hence, the legitimisation effect lies, first and foremost, in the increasing tolerance for the radical party's positions, which are no longer denounced as taboo (Bartels & Mutz 2009; Paluck, Shepherd & Aronow 2016). On the other hand, the success of a radical party can also contribute to the legitimisation of the relevance and salience of a non-economic dimension of political conflict. Voters may change the prevalence given to the different readily available political conflicts simply because they like the position of the radical party in the alternative but salient non-economic dimension. Thus, we depart from

previous studies that either provide accounts strictly focused on norm shifts (e.g. Valentim 2021) or only examine an all-encompassing left-right dimension (e.g. Bischof & Wagner 2019). According to this alternative rationale, the electoral success of a radical party can act as a trigger to alter voters' positions in other politically salient dimensions.

However, this is only part of the story. On the other side of the political spectrum, the breakthrough of a radical party can have a reverse effect. The so-called backlash effect can happen for two main reasons. From the instrumental perspective, voters who were already against the views of the newly entering radical party may consider the radicalisation of their stances to be the only way to stop potential changes of the *status quo* in the opposite direction. By doing this, opposing voters may only want to communicate to their parties that they will electorally punish any alliance with the newcomer. Moreover, theory on expressive polarisation suggests we should expect a backlash effect among opposing voters. According to this second view, opposing voters might move further from the radical party's stance for the intrinsic rewards of acting against the newcomer and with no interest in the political consequences of their move. In this case, feeling the need to react is enough for this group of voters to engage in a backlash movement.

Based on this reasoning, we expect the following:

Polarisation Hypothesis: The entrance of a radical party into parliament for the first time will have a positive effect on the levels of ideological polarisation in a territorial dimension of political competition (H_1).

Legitimisation Hypothesis: The entrance of a radical party into parliament for the first time will cause individuals identifying with its views to move closer to the position of that party in a territorial dimension of political competition (H_{2A}).

Backlash Hypothesis: The entrance of a radical party into parliament for the first time will cause individuals not identifying with its views to move further away from the position of that party in a territorial dimension of political competition (H_{2B}).

Notably, there are reasons to suspect that the hypothesised short-term boost in ideological territorial polarisation might not be accompanied, as several other articles in this special issue suggest, by an increase in affective territorial polarisation. In our view, it would be fair to consider the defining characteristics of territorial group identification as mainly structured by macro-level historical factors and micro-level socialisation processes that have a much longer-term nature and could not be changed in the short run by the breakthrough of radical parties. For this reason, we do not expect national elections to increase affective territorial polarisation. In a nutshell, we believe there are various degrees of elasticity in citizens' political attitudes towards certain issues, with prejudices towards territorial groups being stickier than ideological positions on the territorial dimension of competition. Along these lines, inter-group prejudices should activate at a slower pace, meaning that we should first observe an increase in ideological polarisation on the territorial dimension, if at all.

The pervasiveness of a territorial dimension of competition in Spain

The 1978 Spanish Constitution outlined an open, indeterminate and ambiguous territorial model to be developed by 'normal politics' (Beramendi & Maiz 2004, p. 134; Colomer 1998; Colino 2009). Yet, as a way of attracting the few, but strong, existing PANEs to the constitutional consensus,⁴ the text recognised revenue and expenditure asymmetries among the different autonomous communities (Aja 2003). The text also recognised the way for the different regional groups to gradually increase or equalise their expenditure levels through subsequent decentralising changes, which normally precipitated further

fiscal decentralisation. During the first 20 years, the path to the development of this territorial model was mostly consensual, though its centrifugal nature laid the groundwork for an outstanding expansion in PANEs number and support (Beramendi & Maiz 2004, p. 149). Then, in the subsequent 20 years, the exhaustion of the constitutional mandate for the development of the territorial model opened the door to a more conflictual type of territorial competition (Garmendia Madariaga & León 2020). As a result, both PANEs and mainstream state-wide parties and their multi-level branches experienced changes in their positions on this dimension of competition (Libbrecht et al. 2009; Alonso, Cabeza & Gómez 2015).

The political parties' views on decentralisation are generally related to preferences on the two core, classic ideological dimensions of party competition: the economy and culture (Toubeau & Wagner 2015). Parties on the economic right typically favour decentralisation as a way of improving the efficient production of public goods. Conversely, parties on the economic left oppose decentralisation because it complicates efforts to redistribute wealth. Culturally liberal parties support decentralisation to recognise diversity and local decision-making. By contrast, culturally conservative parties are against it because it erodes national unity and territorial integrity. As Toubeau and Wagner (2015, pp. 98–99) argue, 'for some parties, the two dimensions are consistent in determining positions on decentralisation; for others, they may lead to internal ideological tensions.' It is necessary to know a party's views on key dimensions of political conflict to understand the ideological foundations of said party's position on decentralisation (Elias, Szöcik & Zuber 2015; Massetti & Schakel 2015).

Spanish politics has traditionally been articulated along the left–right dimension that citizens use as a heuristic cue (Torcal & Medina 2007, p. 277). This all-encompassing dimension comprises economic and cultural issues that are strongly aligned in the case of

Spain (Rovny & Polk 2014, p. 8). It also includes traditional cleavages such as religiosity and social class (Calvo, Martínez & Montero 2010). Accordingly, PSOE (Partido Socialista Obrero Español – Spanish Socialist Workers’ Party) is characterised as an economically left-leaning and culturally liberal party (Urquizu 2015). By contrast, PP (Partido Popular – Popular Party) is known to pursue an economically right-leaning and culturally conservative agenda (Balfour 2005). However, the presence of regionally based ethnic groups, particularly in the Basque Country and in Catalonia, and the way of dealing with the recognition of group-based territorial rights, power, or rents generated important divisions within each side of the ideological spectrum up until the Great Recession (Garmendia Madariaga & León 2020). On the right, the PP had a latent tension between its two different ideological stances: the pragmatic regionalism of UCD (Unión de Centro Democrático - Union of Democratic Centre) and the strong Spanish nationalism of AP (Alianza Popular - Popular Alliance). On the left, PCE/IU (Partido Comunista de España/Izquierda Unida - Communist Party of Spain/United Left) had a slightly more consistent territorial position based on intermittent defences of a confederal model. Concurrently, an on-going internal debate was taking place in the PSOE’s ranks about how to make individual equality and regional difference compatible under a potentially federal frame.

The imperfect two-party system in Spain collapsed in the aftermath of the Great Recession with the appearance of two new state-wide parties, Podemos and Ciudadanos (Cs) (Citizens) (Orriols & Cordero 2016; Vidal 2018). As it has been extensively explained, these transformations were tightly connected to the crisis of representation that unfolded alongside the severe economic crisis (Vidal & Sánchez-Vítores 2019). There were young and politically dissatisfied citizens on different sides of the ideological spectrum voting for these two new parties. However, while the pre-crisis period had been

marked by decentralising reforms and ETA terrorism, the territorial conflict took a new direction after the crisis. This is when Catalan PANEs substituted their strategy of claiming further autonomy for a referendum on independence (Pardos-Prado & Sagarzazu 2019).

Notably, both new parties' emergence put a non-negligible programmatic emphasis on this issue. Cs, for instance, was founded in 2006 as a PANE in Catalonia to fight the predominance of ethno-regionalism in Catalan society and politics. It went national with a solid stance against regions' right to independence (Rodríguez-Teruel & Barrio 2015, p. 9). As for Podemos, this became one of the most controversial and yet distinctive positions of the new party. It adapted its populist ideas to Spain's complex identities, particularly to the aspirations of the secessionist movements in Catalonia and the Basque Country. In 2015, Podemos not only supported the idea of a multinational Spain, as other Spanish radical left parties had historically done, but also defended Catalonia's self-determination through a referendum (Rodríguez-Teruel, Barrio & Barberá 2016, p. 573).

The territorial conflict became even more salient after the events of the autumn of 2017 in Catalonia. The unilateral declaration of independence, the celebration of an illegal referendum by the incumbent PANE coalition, the subsequent imprisonment of the promoting leaders, and the successful vote of no confidence led by the PSOE in June 2018 against Mariano Rajoy's government with the support of most PANEs all became the breeding ground for the consolidation of Vox. In 2013, one of the most conservative factions of the PP split from the main party. Although they ran for the 2015 regional and general elections and the 2016 general elections, it was not until the December 2018 Andalusian elections that their representatives were elected for the first time. Vox combined a radical position on the left-right dimension with a hugely critical stance on

the constitutional territorial model and the decentralisation process that had developed it (Ferreira 2019). They vindicated the defence of Spanish identity against ‘the left’ and the ‘secessionists.’

Thereafter, as Vampa (2020) suggests, one of the most notable elements of differentiation at the time of the initial success of these new parties was their positioning on the territorial dimension. Still, we argue here that, unlike the case of Cs, the parliamentary appearance of Podemos and Vox entailed the legitimization of certain territorial positions that had not been previously defended by any state-wide party in the most recent democratic period in Spain.⁵ While their primary focus on the rejection of Catalan right to self-determination granted Cs great success in the 2017 elections in this region, this position did not contradict the traditional state-wide parties’ positions on this particular issue. Conversely, Podemos’s recognition of regions’ right to self-determination and Vox’s defence of a unitary state, both represent two novel and irreconcilable poles of an already exceptionally salient dimension of competition in this country, and thus justify the hypothesized increases in ideological territorial polarisation.

Research design

We conducted two types of analyses employing two different types of data sources to examine whether voters polarise on the territorial dimension of political competition in Spain after a radical party entered parliament. First, we made use of the third and fourth waves of the E-Dem dataset because they were conducted during the April 2019 Spanish general elections (Torcal et al. 2020). This selection allowed us to carefully assess the potential polarising impact of Vox entering Spanish parliament by leveraging the survey’s panel design. We then turned to the CIS panel studies conducted during the 2011 and 2015 Spanish general elections to extrapolate the 2019 findings to a different context.

Based on this second data source, we examined whether the first entry into the Spanish parliament of the radical left party Podemos in 2015 and the lack of any significant change in the party system in 2011 had any impact on the levels of ideological territorial polarisation in the country.

Vox and Podemos constitute ideal cases to study the potential polarising impact of radical parties when they enter a national parliament for the first time. Firstly, even though they were founded around the same time (December 2013 and January 2014 respectively), they entered the national parliament for the first time at different moments (2019 and 2015 general elections, respectively). Second, the choice is appropriate because there is a series of factors that could conceivably cause an attenuation bias of the expected effect. On the one hand, as Simón (2020) and Garmendia Madariaga and León (2020) have noted, territorial polarisation has become one of the main defining features of Spanish politics in the last decade. This long-term process is less likely to produce a short-term polarisation effect when the electoral breakthrough of a radical party occurs. On the other hand, both parties' entries into the national parliament were preceded by previous political successes: the 2014 European Parliament elections for Podemos, and the 2018 Andalusian regional elections for Vox. To a certain extent, this fact reduces the possibility of finding the effect outlined in our theory because the polarising discourse of the radical party was already publicly present before the election under consideration.⁶ Third, we used the 2011, 2015 and 2019 panel election studies to assess within-subject shifts in citizens' attitudes, with repeated measures of voters' territorial preferences at the pre- and post-election waves.⁷

To test our theoretical arguments in 2019, we employed two different dependent variables. First, we employed the respondents' general placement on a decentralisation–centralisation scale ranging from 0 (extreme decentralisation) to 10 (extreme

centralisation).⁸ We analysed ideological territorial polarisation by estimating each respondent's linear distance to the median, which is always 5, before and after the election. From here, we directly examined potential changes after Vox's entry to parliament. We also analysed the same potential change using two measures of affective polarisation (Torcal & Comellas 2022): one of spread of sentiment scores toward four territorial groups (Basques, Catalans, Andalusians and those from the Madrid region) and one of distance from respondents' own territorial group. These are based on the application of Wagner's (2021, pp. 4-5) formulas, with the feeling thermometers adapted to different territorial/national identity groups. These measures of affective territorial polarisation range from 0 (0) to 5 (10), where 0 implies that all territorial groups are valued equally, and 5 (10) means a maximum variation in considerations about different territorial groups (difference in opinions between the respondents' territorial group and others). Secondly, we took as dependent variable the individual movement on the same decentralisation–centralisation scale to assess the post-treatment direction of voters' ideological shifts based on their attitudinal profile.

We also investigated the potential short-term polarising effects (if any) of party system change in the context of the 2015 and 2011 general elections. In this case, we resorted to the traditional CIS question on respondents' preferred formula of territorial organisation of the state: 1) a unitary state with no regional governments, 2) a state with a lower level of power for regional governments than at present, 3) a state with the same level of power for regional governments as today, 4) a state with a higher level of power for regional governments than at present, and 5) a state that grants regions the right to become independent. Unfortunately, the second option is not available for the pre-election wave of the 2011 study, and we excluded respondents that took this option in the

post-election wave of the 2011 study from the analyses. Based on these survey questions, we created two dichotomous dependent variables:

- The first takes value 1 if the respondent does not choose the third option and 0 otherwise.
- The second takes value 1 if the respondent chooses the first or fifth options and 0 otherwise.

In the analyses of the proposed three electoral periods, the key independent variable was dichotomous with values 1 for each respondent after the given election and 0 before the election. Next, just for the 2019 analyses, we created indicators for respondents identifying with right-wing, left-wing, and PANEs in the pre-election wave. We expected right-wing party identifiers (i.e. Vox, PP and Cs) to move further to the centralisation extreme, and left-wing party identifiers (i.e., PSOE and UP [Unidas Podemos - United We Can])⁹ and PANEs' identifiers (i.e., ERC [Esquerra Republicana de Catalunya – Republican Left of Catalonia], JxCat [Junts per Catalunya – Together for Catalonia], PNV [Partido Nacionalista Vasco – Basque Nationalist Party], EH-Bildu [Euskal Herria Bildu – Basque Country Gather] and CC [Coalición Canaria - Canarian Coalition]) to move further to the decentralisation extreme.¹⁰

Some models also included the following list of control variables: age, gender, rural, income, religion, political knowledge and voting preference.¹¹ All the time-variant covariates are observed before the election. Therefore, they cannot operate as the mechanism to explain the shift in voters' general decentralisation–centralisation placement. Apart from age and gender, the municipality size variable is dichotomous and takes value 1 if the respondent lives in a rural area or a village and 0 otherwise. Income is a continuous variable that measures the respondent's net monthly household income divided into 10 categories. Religion is a dichotomous variable that takes value 1 for

respondents with a religious denomination and 0 otherwise. Political knowledge is a continuous variable that ranges from 0 (low political knowledge) to 6 (high political knowledge) depending on how many correct answers the respondent provides to a battery of questions on political facts.¹² Finally, we specified a series of dichotomous variables that take value 1 if the respondent intends to vote for any of the six largest parties (i.e. PP, PSOE, UP, Cs, ERC, and Vox) and 0 otherwise (for the distribution and further details on all the variables see the Online Appendix).

Our main analyses are based on OLS models with robust standard errors at the individual level. Following Bischof and Wagner (2019), in the 2019 analyses we also controlled for the absolute temporal distance to the election.

Short-term effects of radical parties' entry in Spain: Empirical results

April 2019 Spanish General Elections

Figure 1 plots the ideological polarisation of panel respondents on the territorial dimension over the third and fourth waves of the E-Dem dataset using local linear regressions. The polarisation on this dimension increased after the election to a small but still remarkable degree. If we do not consider the last day before the election, this trend is fairly stable across the time period covered by the third wave of the election panel.¹³ Moreover, it is conceivable that short-term polarisation due to the elections may start to decline after 3 weeks, which is approximately when the fieldwork for the fourth wave starts. However, the fact is that the average level of ideological polarisation on the territorial dimension is somewhat higher in the post-election wave than in the pre-election wave.

(Figure 1)

To substantiate this descriptive finding, Table 1 displays results of some regressions that take ideological polarisation on the territorial dimension as the dependent variable. When we do not include control variables (Model 1), the average voters' distance to the median increases significantly after the election ($p < .05$). This increase remains similar in magnitude and statistical significance when we control for the previous list of individual-level covariates (Model 2).¹⁴ Conversely, we do not find a statistically significant increase in ideological territorial polarisation over the waves when we include individual fixed effects (Model 3), suggesting that there is some time-invariant factor missing in the previous list that accounts for the within-subject variation over time.¹⁵

(Table 1)

In Table 2, we display the results of an additional battery of econometric specifications that examine the potential impact of Vox's entrance on affective territorial polarisation. To keep the same number of observations as those in Table 1, we restricted the analyses to those individuals who do not have missing values in the ideological territorial polarisation scale in the third and fourth waves. Independently from the dependent variable that we employ, the coefficients are consistently non-significant at traditional levels of statistical confidence; this speaks to the null effect of the entrance of Vox on affective territorial polarisation.¹⁶

(Table 2)

Next, we investigated the legitimisation and backlash mechanisms in depth to have a more detailed and precise understanding of the registered patterns. As we argued in the hypotheses section, voters' reactions to the entrance into parliament of a radical party should depend on how their political affiliations relate to the ideology of the party entering parliament for the first time. In the case of Vox, voters identifying with right-wing parties should be subject to a legitimisation effect and left-wing party identifiers and respondents identifying with non-state-wide parties should experience a backlash effect.¹⁷ Figure 2 illustrates the results of the analyses of shifts in voters' territorial positioning that are conditioned on party preferences. In the left panel, where we distinguished three large groups of identifiers, some legitimisation and backlash effects are clearly visible. Voters identifying with a right-wing party moved further toward the centralisation extreme of the scale. By contrast, those identifying with a non-state-wide party moved further to the decentralisation extreme. Remarkably, there is no statistically significant movement regarding left-wing identifiers.

(Figure 2)

However, this classification of party identifiers into three large groups conceals considerable heterogeneity in the researched effects within each group. Thus, the right panel of Figure 2 reports more detailed results for each group of party supporters. The national parties in the figure are sorted based on their value in the Comparative Manifesto Project RILE index for the April 2019 Spanish general elections (Volkens et al. 2019). At the bottom of the figure, we display results corresponding to the identifiers of two groups of non-state-wide parties. These are Catalan (ERC, JxCat and Front Republicà-CUP) and Basque (PNV and EH-Bildu).

In general, the estimates are consistent with our theoretical expectations. Within the right-wing camp, Vox and PP (but not Cs) identifiers supported decentralisation even less after the election. Within the left-wing camp, results vary. PSOE identifiers departed from expectations and supported decentralisation slightly less after the election. By contrast, Unidas Podemos identifiers moved in the expected direction and increased support for decentralisation after the election. Finally, both groups of respondents identifying with a non-state-wide party moved further to the decentralisation extreme as suggested by our theory. These results strengthen our confidence in the validity of the arguments of the article for the following reasons. First, the shifts whose direction fits our expectations are significant at conventional levels of statistical confidence. Second, we find the largest movements for the respondents identifying with parties closer to the extremes of the decentralisation–centralisation scale. Conversely, voters identifying with the most centrist parties did not register any remarkable movement. Third, the movement in voters’ territorial preferences occurred in similar ways on both sides of the ideological spectrum.

2011 and 2015 Spanish General Elections

In the other two studies, we used CIS survey data to examine whether the 2011 and 2015 elections contributed to ideological polarisation of Spanish voters on the territorial dimension. We believe focusing on these two previous elections grants our argument the required variation in the scope conditions. While the 2011 general elections unfolded in a highly conflictual socio-economic scenario, no state-wide party entered the national parliament for the first time after running a radical campaign on the territorial dimension. This was different in 2015, when the appearance of Cs and Podemos and their electoral

success contributed to a political realignment in Spain and to the increasing salience of territorial issues.

(Table 3)

Using a similar approach as in Table 1, we first analysed a multi-wave election panel conducted during the 2015 general election and found an increase of ideological territorial polarisation after Podemos' breakthrough (see Table 3). Hence, unlike in Bischof and Wagner's (2019) study, we also find a polarising effect after the entry of a radical left party in Spain. In fact, additional analyses included in the Online Appendix (see Figures B1 and B2) suggest that this increase is due to a backlash effect. After the election, there was a significant increase in the number of people who advocated for the creation of a unitary state without decentralised political power, particularly among right-wing voters. By contrast, we find a depolarising effect of the 2011 election (see Table 4). Overall, the number of voters who advocated for the preservation of the *status quo* increased at least in the short term. In this election, the potential polarising effect of the 15M Movement on the territorial dimension seemed to have been offset by the absence of any new radical party in parliament. Furthermore, it may similarly be a result of the bad economic situation at that moment.

(Table 4)

Conclusions

Support for radical parties has been on the rise in the last decade in Europe. In Spain, the radical left party Podemos and the radical right party Vox exploited the Great Recession and the Catalan crisis, respectively, to guarantee their electoral success and enter parliament. The existing literature has widely analysed the individual determinants of voting for these parties. In this article, we took a different approach.

Using information from two CIS panel studies and the E-Dem dataset, we examined some of the attitudinal consequences of the irruption of these parties into Spanish institutions. Within this framework, we demonstrated how, after Podemos and Vox entered the national parliament for the first time, Spanish voters became more ideologically polarised on the territorial dimension. By contrast, we used the same empirical strategy to indicate no equivalent effect in 2011, when no new radical party entered parliament. Likewise, we found no significant evidence of increasing affective territorial polarisation after the breakthrough of Vox in 2019. This speaks to two relevant aspects of affective polarisation that we believe deserve further research: 1) the relationship between ideological and affective polarisation and 2) the extent to which partisan and territorial affective polarisation are comparable in nature. Moreover, focusing on 2019, our analyses provided evidence of increasingly pro-centralisation preferences for voters supporting right-wing parties and increasingly pro-decentralisation preferences for voters supporting left-wing and non-state-wide parties. Following Bischof and Wagner (2019), we referred to these effects as ‘legitimisation’ and ‘backlash’. In overall terms, ‘legitimisation’ was more important than ‘backlash’ in 2019 since the effect for left-wing voters was practically insignificant, and there are more right-wing voters than non-state-wide-parties’ supporters in our samples.¹⁸

Overall, our findings are important for research on radical parties and political competition in non-economic electoral dimensions. Party systems in Europe have been recently characterised by the success of new competitors, frequently on the fringes of the political scenario. It is important to demonstrate that these events have an impact not only on the traditional left–right scale but also on other salient dimensions of competition across countries. This is particularly important given the weight that some radical parties put on these issue domains in their manifestos. Although in other Southern European countries the parliamentary presence of radical parties has been more sustained over time, our findings suggest that the recent entrance into parliament of the radical right CHEGA in Portugal, the increasing national presence of the Italian Lega or the recent electoral victories of Syriza in Greece might have further contributed to polarizing voters beyond the classical left-right dimension. In fact, according to McCoy and Somer (2019), the territorial divide is a salient discursive dimension contributing to their idea of ‘pernicious polarization’ in Turkey.

Finally, our study has certain limitations that future research should address. First, scholars often need to rely on electoral panel studies when examining this kind of attitudinal changes. However, yearly panels may provide better insights into how polarisation develops in the long term. Second, while allowing a fine-grained look into the mechanisms at play, the present case study does not allow us to adopt a truly comparative perspective. Future research could address this potential pitfall by using panel surveys from other countries. These should contain questions on dimensions of competition other than the traditional left–right scale. Future research may also rely on cross-sectional time-series designs that could leverage comparative survey data. Finally, our study shows that ideological territorial polarisation did not increase after 2011 elections, when no new radical party entered the national parliament. However, this effect

could be also due to the moment in which these elections took place – that is, amidst the Great Recession and before the Catalan secessionist process started. To further test for the robustness of our results, it would be appropriate to examine future elections, where no new radical party emerges, the economic situation is good and tensions in Catalonia continue to be salient.

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Table 1. Regression estimates: The effect of the parliamentary entrance of Vox on ideological territorial polarisation (Spain 2019)

	(1)	(2)	(3)
	Pre/post comparison OLS	Pre/post comparison OLS + Controls	Pre/post comparison OLS + FE
Before/after election	0.484*	0.446*	-0.00634
	(0.202)	(0.204)	(0.169)
Constant	2.908***	2.214***	2.834***
	(0.0656)	(0.231)	(0.0385)
Controls		X	
Individual FE			X
R ²	0.00179	0.0860	0.000331
Obs.	2,418	2,418	2,418
N	1,209	1,209	1,209

Note: Regression coefficients with clustered standard errors by panel id in parentheses; * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$; We also control for the absolute temporal distance to the election.

Source: E-Dem dataset, waves 3-4.

Table 2. Regression estimates: The effect of the parliamentary entrance of Vox on affective territorial polarisation (Spain 2019)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	Spread of sentiment scores toward territorial groups		Mean distance from respondents' own territorial group	
	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison
	OLS	OLS + Controls	OLS	OLS + Controls
Before/after election	0.130 (0.118)	0.166 (0.117)	0.171 (0.191)	0.206 (0.190)
Constant	1.191*** (0.0376)	0.861*** (0.133)	1.359*** (0.0597)	1.060*** (0.217)
Controls		X		X
R ²	0.000670	0.0731	0.000356	0.0338
Obs.	2,418	2,418	2,418	2,418
N	1,209	1,209	1,209	1,209

Note: Regression coefficients with clustered standard errors by panel id in parentheses; * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$; We also control for the absolute temporal distance to the election.

Source: E-Dem dataset, waves 3-4.

Table 3. Regression estimates: The effect of the parliamentary entrance of Podemos on ideological territorial polarisation (Spain 2015)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison
	OLS	OLS + Controls	OLS + FE	OLS	OLS + Controls	OLS + FE
Before/after election	0.0115 (0.00746)	0.0208* (0.00916)	0.0115 (0.00746)	0.0211** (0.00667)	0.0248** (0.00831)	0.0211** (0.00667)
Constant	0.557*** (0.00672)	0.307*** (0.0410)	0.557*** (0.00373)	0.280*** (0.00608)	0.230*** (0.0386)	0.280*** (0.00333)
Controls		X			X	
Individual FE			X			X
R ²	0.000135	0.0437	0.000438	0.000537	0.0240	0.00182
Obs.	10,924	7,108	10,924	10,924	7,108	10,924
N	5,462	3,554	5,462	5,462	3,554	5,462

Note: Regression coefficients with clustered standard errors by panel id in parentheses; * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. In the first three models, polarised takes value 1 if the respondent rejects the *status quo*, and 0 if otherwise. In the last three models, polarised takes value 1 if the respondent prefers a unitary state or granting regions the right to become independent, and 0 if otherwise.

Source: 3,117 and 3,126 CIS studies.

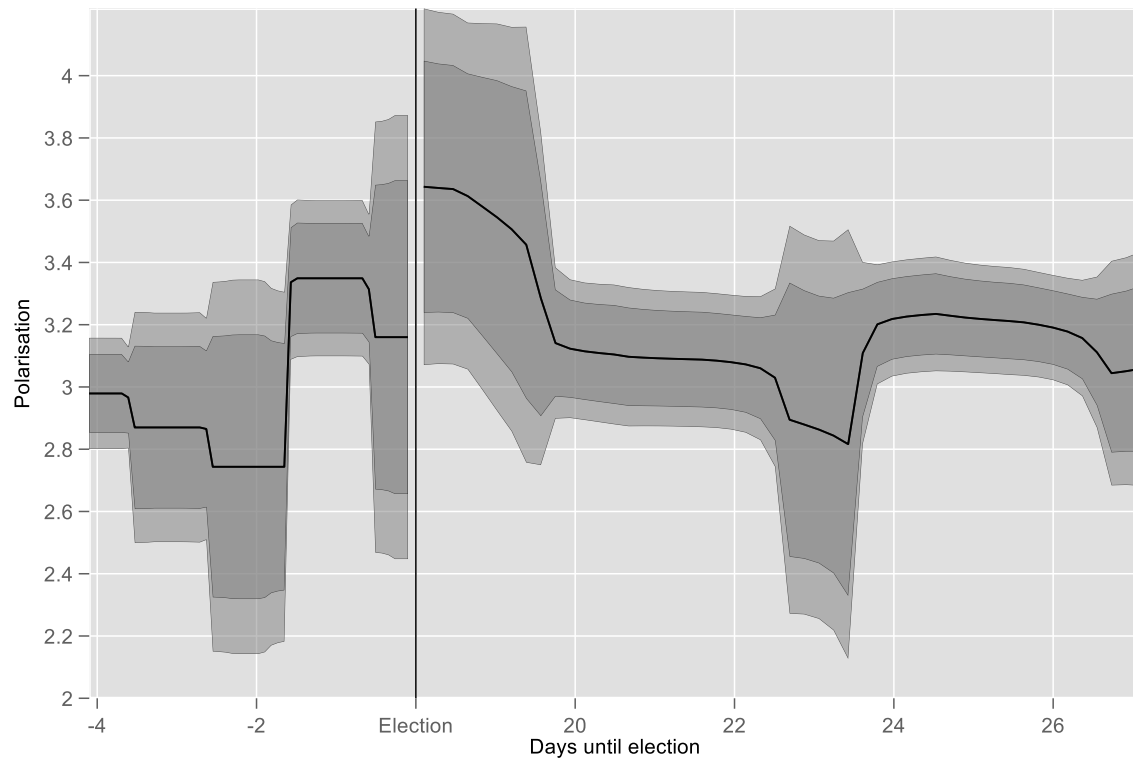
Table 4. Regression estimates: Ideological territorial polarisation when the party system does not change (Spain 2011)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison	Pre/post comparison
	OLS	OLS + Controls	OLS + FE	OLS	OLS + Controls	OLS + FE
Before/after election	-0.0434*** (0.00788)	-0.0421*** (0.00930)	-0.0434*** (0.00788)	-0.0184** (0.00710)	-0.0194* (0.00845)	-0.0184** (0.00710)
Constant	0.483*** (0.00764)	0.425*** (0.0397)	0.483*** (0.00394)	0.323*** (0.00715)	0.159*** (0.0375)	0.323*** (0.00355)
Controls		X			X	
Individual FE			X			X
R ²	0.00190	0.0696	0.00705	0.000395	0.0607	0.00157
Obs.	8,566	6,172	8,566	8,566	6,172	8,566
N	4,283	3,086	4,283	4,283	3,086	4,283

Note: Regression coefficients with clustered standard errors by panel id in parentheses; * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. In the first three models, polarised takes value 1 if the respondent rejects the *status quo*, and 0 if otherwise. In the last three models, polarised takes value 1 if the respondent prefers a unitary state or granting regions the right to become independent, and 0 if otherwise.

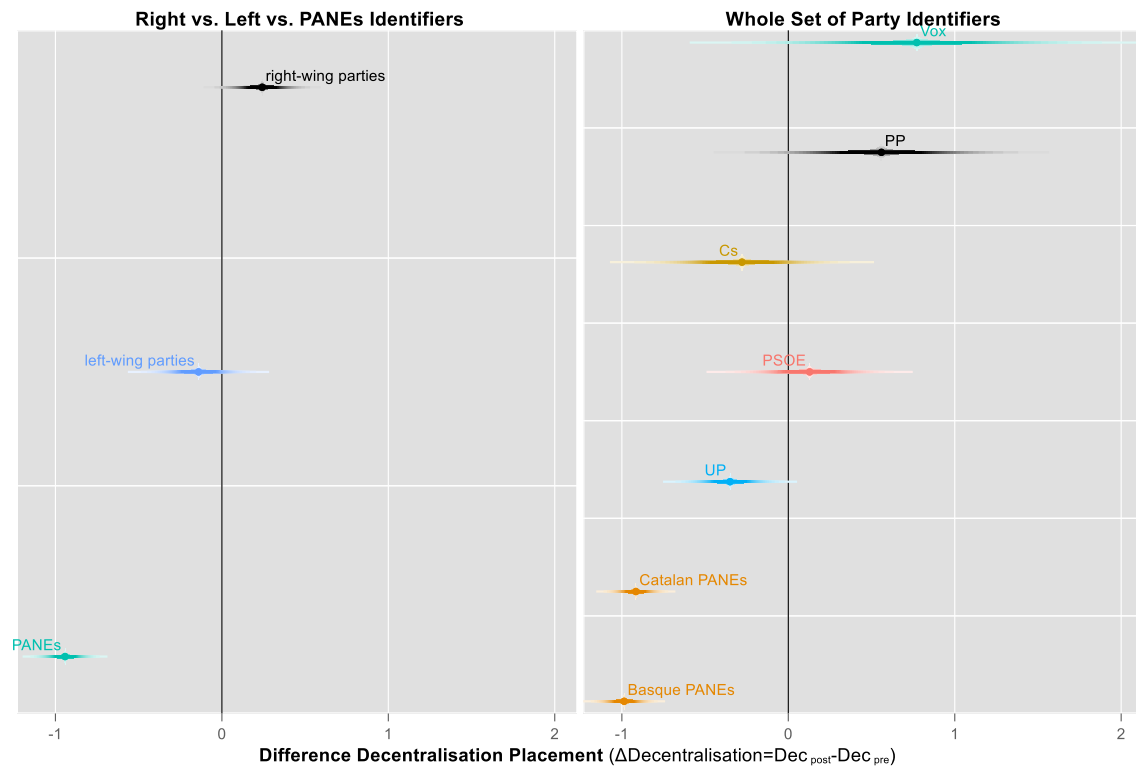
Source: 2,915 and 2,920 CIS studies.

Figure 1. Descriptive statistics: Evolution of ideological territorial polarisation before and after the parliamentary entrance of Vox (Spain 2019)



Note: A comparison of ideological territorial polarisation in waves 3 and 4 of the E-Dem dataset (within-person comparison) is shown. The figure presents local polynomial regression plots, surrounded by 95% and 83.4% confidence intervals; kernel = epanechnikov; degree of smooth = 0.

Figure 2. Effect of party identification on respondents' shifts in territorial positioning (Spain 2019)



Note: The two plots report OLS coefficient estimates with 95% confidence intervals. The full model specifications are reported in Table B3 in the Online Appendix. The outcome variable is the difference between the post-election and pre-election decentralisation–centralisation positions (0–10 scale). Coefficients estimates are for variables indicating whether a respondent identifies with a set of parties (left) or a specific party (right) in the pre-election wave. The left figure presents the coefficients for voters identified with right-wing (Vox, PP and Cs), left-wing (PSOE and UP) and non-statewide (PANEs: ERC, JxCat, PNV, EH-Bildu and CC) parties. The right figure presents the coefficients for each main party ID included in the panel study.

PP = Partido Popular, Cs = Ciudadanos, PSOE = Partido Socialista Obrero Español, UP = Unidas Podemos (Podemos + Izquierda Unida + Equo), Catalan PANEs = ERC + JxCat + CUP-FR (Esquerra Republicana de Catalunya + Junts per Catalunya + Front Republicà-Candidatura d’Unitat Popular), Basque PANEs = PNV + EH-Bildu (Partido Nacionalista Vasco + Euskal Herria-Bildu).

¹ There is a broader debate on the connection between elite and voter ideologies. On the one hand, some studies demonstrate that voters are often inattentive, and changes in party positions thus go unnoticed for them (Adams, Ezrow & Somer-Topcu 2011, 2014). On the other hand, other work indicates that voters react to elite positioning (Adams, Green & Milazzo 2012; Fernández-Vázquez 2014).

² We use the terms ‘autonomous communities’ and ‘regions’ interchangeably in this article.

³ Exceptionally, see Heinisch and Marent (2018) for the Austrian FPÖ’s regional strategy or Vampa (2020) for a descriptive approach to the case of Podemos and Vox.

⁴ Although several autonomous communities in Spain have territorially concentrated distinct cultures (Balearic Islands, Basque Country, Catalonia, Galicia, Navarra, and Valencia), the Basque Country and Catalonia were the only regions to have strong PANEs (i.e. PNV [Partido Nacionalista Vasco – Basque Nationalist Party] and HB [Herri Batasuna – Popular Unity] in the Basque Country, and ERC [Esquerra Republicana de Catalunya – Republican Left of Catalonia] and CiU [Convergència i Unió – Convergence and Union] in Catalonia) with the capacity to politicise the centre-periphery cleavage over time.

⁵ In the 2019 pre-election wave, the average self-placement of Vox voters on the territorial dimension was 7.9, slightly one point more than PP voters (6.88). In the 2015 pre-election wave, almost 17% of Podemos voters advocated for the recognition of regions’ right to independence. In contrast, less than 2% of PSOE voters were in favour of regions’ access to self-determination.

⁶ To account for this fact, the reported analyses do not consider respondents that live in Andalusia.

⁷ A total of 1,659 respondents were interviewed before the election. From these respondents, 1,484 were interviewed again after the election. To draw on a balanced panel, we excluded all respondents who were not interviewed for both waves. In 2011, the fieldwork took place between 6 and 23 October 2011 for the pre-election wave and between 24 November 2011 and 15 January 2012 for the post-election wave. A total of 6,082 respondents were interviewed

for both waves. In 2015, the fieldwork took place between 27 October 2015 and 16 November 2015 for the pre-election wave and between 7 January 2016 and 19 March 2016 for the post-election wave. A total of 6,241 respondents were interviewed in both waves.

⁸ To be more specific, the scale ranges from 0 ('Autonomous Communities should have more legislative powers.') to 10 ('The Central Government should be given back some powers.').

⁹ Unidas Podemos is the pre-electoral coalition formed by Podemos, IU and Equo to contest the April 2019 general elections.

¹⁰ We also treated as left-wing party identifiers the respondents identifying with Actua, Equo and En Marea and as PANEs identifiers the respondents identifying with BNG (Bloque Nacionalista Galego – Galician Nationalist Bloc), CUP (Candidatura d'Unitat Popular – Popular Unity Candidacy), Front Republicà (Republican Front) and Geroa Bai (Yes to the Future). We omitted other very small parties with few identifiers and a mixed ideological profile (i.e. Compromís [Commitment], Escaños en Blanco [Seats in White], PACMA [Partido Animalista contra el Maltrato Animal – Animalist Party Against Mistreatment of Animals], Partido Libertario [Libertarian Party] and UPyD [Unión Progreso y Democracia - Union, Progress and Democracy]) from this analysis. We likewise removed respondents identifying with two parties that belong to different blocs at the same time.

¹¹ The exact operationalisation of income, rural, political knowledge, and voting preferences slightly changed in 2015 and 2011. Regarding income, in 2015, the scale had 11 categories rather than 10. Regarding rural, the variable took value 1 if the respondent lived in a habitat of less than 2,001 inhabitants and 0 otherwise. Regarding political knowledge, the scale had four possible values rather than seven. Regarding voting preferences, in 2011, the six most voted parties in the sample were PP, PSOE, IU, UPyD, CiU, and Amaiur. Conversely, in 2015, the six most voted parties were PP, PSOE, Podemos, Ciudadanos, IU, and ERC. Further details about the coding and descriptive statistics of all variables can be found in Tables A1-A3 in the Online Appendix.

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- ¹² In 2019, the questions refer to the name of the Minister of Defense, the size of the Lower Chamber, the age requirements to run in the national elections, the number of MPs each European Union (EU) country elects to the European Parliament, Norway EU membership and the number of EU countries.
- ¹³ The number of respondents placing themselves at 5, the mid-point of the scale, also decreases from 18.61% to 17.78% between the third and the fourth waves. This is another sign of increasing polarisation. Focusing on respondents who in the pre-election wave place themselves at 5, Figure A1 of the Online Appendix indicates that previously centrist respondents are slightly more likely to adopt a pro-centralisation rather than a pro-decentralisation position in the 2019 post-election wave. This provides preliminary evidence of a backlash effect. Figures A2-A3 of the Online Appendix display the results of analogous analyses for 2015 and 2011.
- ¹⁴ Note that we are probably in front of an attenuation effect here because, even though the entrance of Vox into the parliament was not confirmed until April 28, the party was going to obtain parliamentary representation according to all pre-election polls. For example, the CIS pre-election poll released on the 9th of April forecasted between 29 and 37 seats for Vox. As Figure 1 indicates, these good electoral prospects do not seem to increase polarisation by themselves either.
- ¹⁵ This impact of Vox's entrance on ideological territorial polarisation is further corroborated when Table B1 of the Online Appendix summarizes the results obtained through a battery of OLS regressions that examine the evolution of this variable over waves of the E-Dem dataset. The results indicate that there is no significant variation in the registered level of ideological territorial polarisation between waves 1 and 2 and waves 2 and 3.
- ¹⁶ Using the distance from Catalans and Basque leads to the same conclusion (see Table B2 in the Online Appendix).

¹⁷ Note that our findings remain similar if we use the respondents' intended vote rather than identification as a key independent variable. This is true, except for the respondents who intend to vote for a Catalan non-state-wide party (see Figure B3 in the Online Appendix).

¹⁸ In 2015, 'backlash' seems to be more important than 'legitimisation' suggesting that: 1) right-wing voters are more shaped by these dynamics than left-wing voters; 2) there is an overall trend towards preferring less decentralisation.